world, just as there appeared to be only one cat in the box and one you looking at it. This is a hallmark of the many-worlds interpretation: the appearance of a single world, despite the true existence of many.

When Everett finished a draft of his thesis in January 1956, Wheeler was the first to see it. Wheeler had enormous respect for Everett's abilities. Writing to the NSF, Wheeler said that Everett "originated an apparent paradox in the interpretation of the measurement problem in quantum theory.… In discussions of this paradox with graduate students and staff members here at Princeton, and with Niels Bohr, Everett brought to light new features of the problem that make it in and of itself an appropriate subject for an outstanding thesis when further developed.… [Everett] really is an original man."

But Wheeler was caught between several competing interests. He wanted to support a brilliant student's work, and he also wanted to find a way forward with quantum cosmology; supporting Everett's idea of a "universal wave function" would further both of those interests. But Wheeler also wanted to remain loyal to his mentor and friend, Bohr. Indeed, Wheeler idolized Bohr, writing that "nothing has done more to convince me that there once existed friends of mankind with the human wisdom of Confucius and Buddha, Jesus and Pericles, Erasmus and Lincoln, than walks and talks under the beech trees of Klampenborg Forest with Niels Bohr."

Wheeler was a political animal; he knew how to work with others and how to keep other people happy with his ideas, in exactly the way that Einstein could not. He knew that supporting Everett at the cost of his relationship with Bohr was a bad career move. "John Wheeler got along with everybody," recalled Misner. "But in Hugh's case, Wheeler had a very difficult time applying his usual tactics because he couldn't just encourage Hugh to follow his ideas and present them as powerfully as possible, since they ran contrary to Bohr's ideas." But Wheeler was also unwilling to give up Everett's theory of a universal wave function—he saw it as a possible path forward for quantum gravity, an opportunity too good to pass up. This